of water taken from the underground and the amount of water that goes into the underground during the rainy season are equal. On the contrary, as the amount of water taken increases, the ground water goes down resulting in complete dryness or change into unusable water.

The Union Ground Water Board is constantly monitoring the level and nature of ground water.

From this, we come to know that:

1. Tamil Nadu agriculture is dependent on groundwater.
2. It is very urgent and necessary to regulate the usage of underground water.
3. This is very important for sustainable farming.

Virtual water

The term 'virtual water' was introduced by Tony Allen in 1990.

The water consumed in the production process of an agricultural or industrial product is called 'virtual water'.

It is the hidden flow of water when food or other commodities are traded from one place to another. For instance, it takes 1340 cubic metres of water (based on the world average) to produce one metric ton of wheat. That is, if one metric ton of wheat is exported to another country, it means that 1340 cubic metres of water used to cultivate this amount of wheat is also being exported.

India is the largest global freshwater user. India has been the fifth largest exporter of virtual water in the world



4.4 Irrigation and Crop types

Crops in Tamil Nadu

All cultivated crops can be classified as food crops and non-food crops. 57 percentage of the total land under food grain cultivation is irrigated. In 2014-15, 59 percentage of food crops and 50 percentage of non food crops were irrigated in Tamil Nadu.

The total area of land cultivated in Tamil Nadu was 59 lakh and 94 thousand hectares in 2014-2015. Out of this non-food crops were 76%.

Paddy cultivation is carried out at a large scale of 30 percent cultivated land area and other food crops in 12 percent area. Millets

Micro irrigation

Micro irrigation technology is a very good remedial measure to tackle shortage in irrigational water. This irrigation technology helps to have a higher yield when compared to the traditional irrigation methods. As only required amount of water is supplied at regular intervals, it increases the ability of water usage and productivity of the crop resulting in reduction of labour expenses and weed growth in the field. As the fertilizer is distributed through water, it increases the usage of fertilizer and the yield. As Tamil Nadu gets insufficient rainfall, the government has taken many measures to implement micro irrigation for proper distribution of water to crops that require more water.



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